

THE AMERICAS

THE AMERICAS ARE MADE UP of two continents—North America and South America. North America includes the Caribbean islands and Central America, the narrow strip of mountainous land that links the two continents.

South America is generally warmer than North America and contains the greatest variety of bird species on Earth. It was cut off from the other continents for millions of years and many of its birds, such as the hoatzin, the oilbird, rheas, and trumpeters are found nowhere else.

Continents on the move

The Earth's thin surface layer, or crust, is made up of several gigantic pieces called plates, which float on a much thicker layer of liquid rock underneath them. Powerful forces within the Earth move the plates extremely slowly around the globe, carrying the continents with them. This movement is known as continental drift. The continents of North and South America have not always been in the position they are in today. Over millions of years, continental drift has pulled the two continents apart and pushed them together again, altering their shape and landscape.



About 200 million years ago
all the continents were joined together in one landmass known as Pangaea, but this was slowly beginning to break apart.



About 50 million years ago
North America had separated from Europe and Asia, and South America was an island on its own. Many unique and unusual birds evolved in South America because the birds could not mix with those in other continents.



About 3 million years ago
the continents had moved into roughly their current positions. South America had joined up with North America. Birds could use the land bridge of Central America to move north and south between the two continents.

Almost half the world's bird species either breed in the tropical rainforests of South America or visit them on migration.

By contrast, North America has fewer unique species and its bird life is less varied. One reason for this is the large number of cities and farms in the region, but the colder climate is also important. There is less food and shelter available and many birds have to migrate to Central and South America during cold seasons. Also, the last Ice Age wiped out many North American birds or drove them south.

AMAZING BIRDS OF THE AMERICAS

Tiniest bird

The bee hummingbird is the smallest bird in the world. An adult male is only 2.2 in (5.7 cm) long.



Bee hummingbird
(*Mellisuga helenae*)

Slowest flight

The American woodcock flies incredibly slowly for a bird at only 5 mph (8 kph).

Fastest spread

In 1890, 120 starlings were introduced to New York. In only 60 years, they had spread across most of North America.

Heaviest nest

The bald eagle builds the largest nest of any bird. A single nest can weigh 4,400 lb (2,000 kg), about the same as two army jeeps.

Deepest dive

The thick-billed murre, or Brünnich's guillemot, dives up to 690 ft (210 m).

Quickest runner

The greater roadrunner is the fastest-running flying bird. It runs up to 18 mph (29 kph).



Greater roadrunner
(*Geococcyx californianus*)

Climate and landscape

The Americas stretch from the Arctic in the north almost down to Antarctica in the south. All the major types of habitat in the world can be found there, including dark evergreen forests, sunny broad-leaved woodlands, dry grasslands, humid rainforests, deserts, and swamps. Two huge mountain ranges—the Rockies and the Andes—stretch down the western side of the region and stop some birds moving freely from east to west.

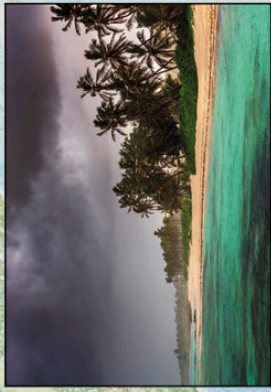
A R C T I C
O C E A N

H U D S O N
B A Y

N O R T H
A M E R I C A

G R E A T
L A K E S

M I S S I S S I P P I



Heavy storms occur in the Caribbean Sea in late summer. They can blow birds migrating from North America off course.